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Appetizers

Main Courses

Breads

Country Loaf

Prep Time: 3 days | **Cook Time:** 45 mins | **Servings:** 1 loaf **Contributor:** Patrick

Description

A brief, 1-2 sentence story or description of the dish. Why is it special?

Ingredients

- ☐ 500 grams **bread flour**
- ☐ 350 grams **water**
- ☐ 100 grams **active sourdough starter** (see Day 1 instructions below)
- ☐ 12 grams **sea salt**

Instructions

Day 1

1. **Prepare the levain:** In a jar, set aside 5 grams of mature sourdough starter. To it, add 50 grams of water and 50 grams of flour.
2. **Mix well:** Mix the above ingredients together well, so that everything is well incorporated. There should be no dry spots of flour.
3. **Let ferment:** Loosely cover the jar, and let sit at room temperature (72 to 75 Fahrenheit) for 10 hours.

Day 2

1. **Hydrate the starter:** In a large bowl, mix together the water and starter. Try to dissolve any large clumps of starter in the water. The water should become frothy.
2. **Mix the dough:** Add the flour to the bowl, and mix thoroughly. Keep mixing until no more loose flour is visible. Be sure to scrape down the sides of the bowl as you go.
3. **Let rest:** Cover the bowl with a plate (or other lid), and let the flour hydrate for 30 minutes.
4. **Add the salt:** Sprinkle the salt over the dough. With a *wet* hand, squeeze and fold the dough so that the salt is evenly distributed and no longer visible.

5. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
6. **Stretch and fold 1:** Perform the first set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.
7. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
8. **Stretch and fold 2:** Perform the second set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.
9. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
10. **Stretch and fold 3:** Perform the third and final set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.
11. **Bulk ferment:** Cover the bowl and let the dough rest on the counter. Depending on the temperature of your room (and the temperature of the dough), the dough should rest for 1.5 to 2 hours. On a hot or warm day, it may take less time. During the winter, you may need to rest the dough for longer.
12. **Preshaping:** When the dough is soft, pillowy, and risen 20% to 30%, it is time to preshape the dough. Turn the dough out onto a floured work surface. Gently work the dough into a taught ball. Cover with the bowl (or towel) and let rest 20 minutes.
13. **Shaping:** Uncover the dough, and flour the surface. Flip the dough over. Grab a small portion of the edge of the dough and pull it towards the middle. Slightly press down. Do this with each corner of the dough until it is roughly circular in shape. Roll the dough over so the folded side is touching the counter. With your hands, drag and seal the dough into a taught ball.
14. **Cold proof:** Flour a proofing basket or a towel-lined bowl. Place the dough smooth side down in the basket. Cover the basket, and place it in the fridge to rest overnight.

Day 3

1. **Preheat the oven:** Place a cast iron pot (with lid) in the oven, and set it to 500F. Let the oven preheat for an hour.
2. **Scoring:** Take the dough out of the oven, and turn it out on to a sheet of

parchment paper. Using a razor blade, slash the dough at a 45-degree angle from one end to the other. Take the cast iron pot out of the oven, and lower the dough into the pot with the parchment paper.

3. **Bake:** Cover the cast iron pot with the lid. Place the pot into the oven. Bake for 20 minutes. Remove the lid, and bake uncovered for another 20 minutes. When the loaf is a dark, golden brown, remove it from the oven.
4. **Cool:** Let the loaf rest for two hours on a cooling rack before slicing.

□ **Chef's Tip:** > Insert any special variations, ingredient substitutions, or pairing suggestions here!